THESIS-DRIVEN ESSAY

Beneath the Maple Leaf: Unmasking Canada's Colonial Legacy and Indigenous Realities Within its National Identity

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MC50 Multimodal Communications

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Canada's image of harmony and inclusivity conceals a darker reality: beneath the surface of multicultural pride lies a legacy of colonialism and the ongoing marginalization of Indigenous peoples. The country's reputation as a welcoming, tolerant, and progressive society is central to its national identity, drawing admiration both within and beyond its borders. This narrative is reinforced by symbols of inclusion, such as multicultural festivals and Canada's Charter of Rights and Freedoms (Government of Canada, 2019), which enshrine principles of equality and non-discrimination.[1] However, this idealized version of Canada presents an incomplete picture, disregarding a long history of colonial policies and practices that sought to erase Indigenous cultures, languages, and sovereignty. Moreover, the consequences of these policies are not relics of the past; the ongoing struggles for land rights, the enduring legacy of residential schools, and the persistent failure to address systemic issues like intergenerational trauma and discrimination reveal contradictions within the carefully polished image that Canada wishes to sustain. This paper seeks to challenge the misrepresentation of Canada's national identity by looking into the historical and continuing impacts of colonialism on Indigenous communities. In doing so, it aims to uncover the complex realities of Canadian nationalism and expose the disparities between its professed values of inclusivity and the lived experiences of its First Nations peoples.[2]

The romanticized portrayal of Canada as a multicultural society often conceals the colonial foundations upon which the country was built. While the ideal of multiculturalism

[1] #context: This is a strong application of #context because it provides background to the widely accepted narrative of Canada's "harmonious" public image. By grounding this perception with the Charter of Rights and Freedoms (*Government of Canada, 2019*), these statements lay a foundation for understanding how this image has been constructed. This framing is crucial for later dissecting the mischaracterization, as it allows for a meaningful contrast between Canada's public image and the often-overlooked realities of Indigenous marginalization.

[2] #thesis: #thesis is well used here because it establishes the paper's central argument: challenging the misrepresentation of Canada's national identity by examining the impacts of colonialism on Indigenous communities. By framing the thesis around the contrast between Canada's professed values of inclusivity and the lived experiences of First Nations peoples, the statement sets up a critical exploration of Canadian nationalism.

gained prominence in the mid-20th century as a response to increasing immigration, it was largely designed without meaningful inclusion of Indigenous perspectives, as Wayland (1997) highlights. Multiculturalism sought to assimilate newcomers into a unified Canadian identity, yet it ignored the distinct status of Indigenous peoples as the original stewards of the land. This exclusion shows the colonial mindset that continues to shape Canadian policy and societal norms, relegating Indigenous peoples to the role of secondary citizens within their own territories. This perspective of Indigenous communities as an afterthought is exemplified by the widespread dispossession of their lands through unfair treaties and outright land confiscation. Treaties were often negotiated under circumstances of unequal power. Indigenous leaders were misled, pressured, or forced into agreements that stripped them of territories in exchange for promises of protection, resources, or compensation that were rarely fulfilled. For example, the numbered treaties, which cover much of Canada's western provinces, were presented as mutual agreements but often included language that Indigenous signatories either could not understand or were assured would not harm their sovereignty (Hall, 2011). Beyond the treaties, land confiscation without consent further exemplified the systemic disregard for Indigenous rights. Government policies like the Indian Act restricted Indigenous control over their territories, making it easier for settlers to exploit these lands (Parrott, 2006). Even today, legal battles over unceded territories, such as those in British Columbia, highlight the long-standing inequities. These disputes over land rights reveal the persistence of colonial structures, with Indigenous peoples enduring systemic exploitation and unfilled commitments.[3] The challenges they face

[3] #organization: This is a strong application of #organization because the paragraph is structured effectively to support the paper's central argument. It starts with a clear topic sentence directly tied to the #thesis. Evidence is then presented to suppport the claims, followed by a detailed unpacking of the evidence to provide depth and explanation. Then, the concluding sentence does not just summarize but synthesizes the argument, drawing broader implications that transition into the next paragraph.

highlight Canada's failure to honour promises made in treaties, reflecting a national identity still deeply rooted in colonial injustice.

While the colonial history regarding land rights sets a critical foundation, the lasting impact of its recent colonial practices, residential schools, exposes what this "harmonious national identity" seeks to conceal. These institutions, which operated well into the late 20th century with the last school closing in 1996, show a direct and systemic attempt to assimilate Indigenous peoples. As Srikanth (2012) notes, residential schools forcibly removed Indigenous children from their families, subjecting them to cultural erasure, physical abuse, and neglect. The trauma inflicted by these schools has left deep scars within Indigenous communities, creating a legacy of intergenerational pain and loss (Miller, 2012). Recent discoveries of unmarked graves at former residential school sites have brought these atrocities into sharper public focus, serving as a chilling reminder of the scale of this systemic violence. Shocking new evidence—such as the discovery of over 200 graves at a single site, with investigations covering only a fraction of known locations—has exposed the widespread nature of these abuses (Austen & Bracken, 2024). The graves are reminders of the lives lost and the families irreparably broken. Despite this, the government's limited efforts to investigate these findings, alongside the media's tendency to downplay their significance, reflect a broader reluctance to fully confront Canada's colonial legacy (Austen & Bracken, 2022).[4] This avoidance sustains a sanitized image of Canada that prioritizes its reputation as a harmonious nation over addressing the lived realities of Indigenous

[4] #evidencebased: This is a good example of #evidencebased because the paragraph is well-supported by multiple credible sources that substantiate its claims about the impact of residential schools. By citing Srikanth (2012), Miller (2012), and Austen & Bracken (2024), the paragraph draws on diverse evidence, including historical analysis, documented trauma, and contemporary findings such as unmarked graves. This use of evidence not only illustrates the systemic nature of these injustices but also ties them to ongoing patterns of denial and avoidance.

peoples. By refusing to confront its colonial past, with injustices such as unmarked graves being sidelined, Canada perpetuates a national identity rooted in denial.

Regarding the disregard for injustice, in the aftermath of residential school closures, Canada introduced reconciliation efforts, such as the establishment of the National Day for Truth and Reconciliation (Truth and Reconciliation Commission of Canada, 2015). However, despite these symbolic gestures and the country's stated commitment to reconciliation with Indigenous peoples, persistent discrimination continues to stand in stark contrast to its cultivated national image. While reconciliation initiatives hold symbolic value, they frequently fail to deliver substantive change. Government reports outlining reconciliation strategies are often undermined by political and legal barriers, resulting in limited tangible benefits for Indigenous communities. For example, although compensation has been awarded to residential school survivors, many Indigenous communities still lack access to clean drinking water—a fundamental human right (Government of Canada, 2021).[5] The federal government has repeatedly missed its own deadlines to address this crisis, and dozens of communities remain under long-term boil-water advisories. Public education initiatives about Indigenous history further exemplify this contradiction. While Canadian schools increasingly incorporate Indigenous history into their curriculum, many reserves continue to struggle with unreliable access to education (Government of Canada, 2018). Similarly, on the topic of land rights, disputes such as the Wet'suwet'en opposition to pipeline construction on unceded territory (Amnesty International, 2023) and the logging of Fairy Creek Pahcheedaht old-growth forests (Cox, 2021), highlight the government's

[5] #sourcequality: This is a strong application of #sourcequality because the paragraph uses authoritative and credible sources that enhance the validity of my claims. The use of the Truth and Reconciliation Commission of Canada (2015) provides a foundational and well-vetted document that is central to discussions of reconciliation efforts. Similarly, referencing the Government of Canada (2021) adds current and official data to highlight the gap between stated commitments and actual outcomes. Both sources are current and highly relevant, with accurate and verified information that supports the critique of reconciliation efforts.

ongoing disregard for Indigenous perspectives. Despite decades of advocacy and claims of reconciliation, Indigenous peoples' lands are still being taken without consent, and their rights continue to be trampled under the weight of economic interests.

In addition to these material inequities, the enduring legacies of intergenerational trauma caused by violent colonization remain inadequately addressed. The ongoing crisis of Missing and Murdered Indigenous Women and Girls (MMIWG) is a prominent example of systemic neglect as reports and calls for action continue to be met with insufficient responses, leaving countless families without justice or closure (Native Hope, 2024). Likewise, the substance abuse epidemic, driven by cycles of poverty and trauma, is often framed as an internal issue within Indigenous communities rather than as a systemic failure requiring national attention and support (Urbanoski, 2017). These realities—alongside countless other examples of disparity—highlight the profound gap between Canada's rhetorical commitment to reconciliation and its failure to enact meaningful, structural change. While reconciliation efforts have brought visibility to some issues, they have not yet dismantled the systemic oppression that continues to marginalize Indigenous peoples. Without addressing these foundational inequities and prioritizing the needs and rights of Indigenous peoples, Canada's genuine commitment to justice will remain in question, and reconciliation will remain an unfulfilled promise.[6]

In closing, Canada's image as a harmonious and inclusive society is built on a selective narrative that glosses over its colonial roots and the systemic marginalization of Indigenous

[6] #composition: This passage from "These realities…" demonstrates a clear and precise writing style that effectively communicates the argument, in line with #composition. The language is direct and bold, avoiding passive voice, stilted diction, or unnecessary complexity. Transitions between ideas are smooth and the sentences respects the principle of parsimony by using concise wording while maintaining clarity. Furthermore, the choice (above this passage) to paraphrase complex issues rather than overloading the text with quotations creates a seamless integration of ideas.

peoples. This idealized portrayal of multiculturalism and reconciliation often obscures a harsh reality: the nation's failure to adequately address the ongoing impacts of colonialism. Despite gestures toward inclusivity, the continued exploitation of Indigenous lands from unfair treaties, the legacy of residential schools, and the neglect of critical issues like Missing and Murdered Indigenous Women and Girls (MMIWG) reveal a significant gap between rhetoric and reality. The implications of this failure are profound, as it jeopardizes not only the credibility of Canada's national identity but also its capacity to achieve genuine social cohesion and justice. By perpetuating an incomplete narrative, Canada risks entrenching historical injustices and deepening divisions rather than healing them.

True reconciliation requires more than just symbolic gestures or partial acknowledgment of past harms. It demands systemic change, including the implementation of policies that uphold Indigenous sovereignty, reparations for historical injustices, and the dismantling of institutional structures that perpetuate inequality. Moreover, reconciliation must involve a genuine partnership with Indigenous communities, prioritizing their voices in shaping the future of the nation. Until Canada fully acknowledges the scope of its colonial legacy and takes meaningful steps to rectify these disparities, its claims of justice and reconciliation will remain unfulfilled promises. By confronting these uncomfortable truths and addressing the deep-seated inequalities within its borders, Canada can move beyond its idealized image and transform its aspirational identity into a lived reality all while upholding the rights and dignity of Indigenous peoples.[7]

WORD COUNT: 1422 WORDS

[7] #professionalism: Overall my completion of this assignment shows #professionalism because it demonstrates a thorough and thoughtful approach by using all the HCs effectively. The work adheres to all formatting guidelines, with attention to detail and respect for academic standards. Starting the assignment early allowed for careful planning and execution, avoiding last-minute rushing and ensuring high-quality output. The word count was maintained and additionally, the work draws on course learnings, prior pre-works, and feedback from classes, showing a deep engagement with the material and a commitment to continuous improvement.

AI STATEMENT

In this assignment, I used minimal AI assistance because of my deep passion and extensive pre-existing knowledge about the topic. This subject is important to me, and I wanted to ensure my essay strongly reflected my personal stance and understanding. Exploring Canada's national identity, its colonial legacy, and the ongoing marginalization of Indigenous peoples required a nuanced and informed perspective, which I aimed to provide through my own experiences and research.

Furthermore, the niche nature of this topic posed challenges for relying on AI tools, as they often provide broad or generalized information that lacks the specificity and context required for my argument. Many examples in my essay, such as the Fairy Creek protest, substance abuse, access to clean water, and education challenges on reserves, were drawn from personal discussions and lived experiences. For instance, my involvement with the Pacheedaht alliances to protect old-growth forests at Fairy Creek deeply informed my analysis. Additionally, my understanding of governmental documents like the *Charter of Rights and Freedoms* and reconciliation efforts stems from my upbringing and education in Canada, where these topics were frequently explored in school.

While AI played a minor role, I did use it for some more tedious tasks. For example, I used ChatGPT to summarize lengthy research papers (after reading them) to help me create ideas for annotations. I used MyBib for citation formatting and Grammarly/Google Docs spell-checker for grammar and spell-checking. These tools helped me refine my writing, but the core arguments, examples, and structure came entirely from my own knowledge, hopefully reflecting my authentic voice and perspective.

ANNOTATED BIBLIOGRAPHY

Amnesty International. (2023, December 11). *Criminalization, unlawful surveillance of Wet'suwet'en land defenders*. Amnesty International. https://www.amnesty.org/en/latest/news/2023/12/canada-amnesty-criminalization-surveillance-wetsuweten-land-defenders/

This report by Amnesty International highlights the criminalization and surveillance faced by Wet'suwet'en land defenders who oppose the construction of the Coastal GasLink pipeline on unceded territory. Amnesty International critiques the Canadian government's actions, suggesting that they violate Indigenous rights and freedoms. This document sheds light on the ongoing resistance to government-sanctioned development projects on Indigenous lands, framing them as both a legal and human rights issue.

Austen, I., & Bracken, A. (2024, September 20). *Unmarked Graves at Canada's Former Indigenous Schools Fuel A Debate*. Nytimes.com; The New York Times. https://www.nytimes.com/2024/09/20/canada-indigenous-schools-unmarked-graves.html

This article from *The New York Times* discusses the discovery of unmarked graves at former residential school sites across Canada, a finding that has intensified debates over Canada's colonial legacy. Austen and Bracken provide an overview of the historical context of residential schools, the trauma inflicted upon Indigenous communities, and the political responses to these discoveries, raising questions about national reconciliation efforts. The article

also explores the broader societal implications of these revelations, including their impact on public consciousness and Canada's self-identity.

Cox, S. (2021, July 1). *Inside the Pacheedaht Nation's stand on Fairy Creek logging blockades*. The Narwhal. https://thenarwhal.ca/pacheedaht-fairy-creek-bc-logging/

Cox's article in *The Narwhal* provides an in-depth look at the Pacheedaht Nation's involvement in and views on the Fairy Creek logging blockades, where environmentalists and Indigenous land defenders are trying to protect one of Canada's last remaining old-growth forests. It examines the complex dynamics between Indigenous rights, environmental protection, and economic interests, analyzing the tension between conservation efforts and resource extraction. Additionally, it highlights internal divisions within the Pacheedaht Nation, illustrating how Indigenous communities face unique pressures when navigating external activism and economic opportunities.

Government of Canada. (2019). *The Canadian Charter of Rights and Freedoms*. Justice.gc.ca; Government of Canada. https://www.justice.gc.ca/eng/csj-sjc/rfc-dlc/ccrf-ccdl/

This official government document outlines the Canadian Charter of Rights and Freedoms, which is a fundamental legal foundation for individual rights in Canada. While not specific to Indigenous issues, the Charter's principles are relevant to Indigenous rights, as Indigenous communities use it to argue for protections and freedoms that are sometimes overlooked in favor of development projects or political agendas. The Charter is also invoked in legal battles addressing systemic inequities, illustrating its potential to challenge colonial legacies and advance Indigenous sovereignty within Canada's legal framework.

Government of Canada, O. of the A. G. of C. (2018, May 29). *Report 5—Socio-economic Gaps on First Nations Reserves—Indigenous Services Canada*. Www.oag-Bvg.gc.ca. https://www.oag-bvg.gc.ca/internet/English/parl_oag_201805_05_e_43037.html

This report from the Office of the Auditor General of Canada evaluates the socio-economic disparities facing First Nations communities, particularly on reserves. It reveals significant gaps in health, education, and economic opportunities for Indigenous peoples, attributing many of these issues to inadequate government support and policies. This report is frequently referenced in discussions of systemic inequality affecting Indigenous populations.

Government of Canada, O. of the A. G. of C. (2021, February 25). *Report 3—Access to Safe Drinking Water in First Nations Communities—Indigenous Services Canada*. Www.oag-Bvg.gc.ca. https://www.oag-bvg.gc.ca/internet/English/parl_oag_202102_03_e_43749.html

This governmental report addresses the critical issue of water access on First Nations reserves, acknowledging the government's repeated failure to ensure safe drinking water for all Indigenous communities. The report examines the reasons behind these persistent boil-water advisories and proposes recommendations, highlighting the gap between governmental promises and the realities on reserves. It highlights how systemic barriers, such as inadequate infrastructure and underfunded services, perpetuate health and safety risks in these communities, calling for urgent and sustained action to close these gaps.

Hall, A. J. (2011, June 6). *Treaties with Indigenous Peoples in Canada | The Canadian Encyclopedia*. The Canadian Encyclopedia. https://www.thecanadianencyclopedia.ca/en/article/aboriginal-treaties

Hall's article provides an overview of treaties between Indigenous peoples and the Canadian government, covering historical contexts and contemporary challenges. Hall emphasizes the power imbalances and misunderstandings during treaty negotiations, which often resulted in Indigenous peoples being deprived of their lands. This source is foundational for understanding the historical basis of land disputes in Canada.

Miller, J. R. (2012, October 10). *Residential Schools in Canada*. The Canadian Encyclopedia; Historica Canada. https://www.thecanadianencyclopedia.ca/en/article/residential-schools

This source provides an overview of the history and legacy of residential schools in Canada, detailing their establishment, purpose, and impact on Indigenous communities. Miller explores how these institutions were a central tool of colonial assimilation policies, designed to eradicate Indigenous cultures, languages, and traditions. The article also discusses the long-term consequences of residential schools, including intergenerational trauma and ongoing challenges faced by Indigenous peoples, valuable for understanding the systemic nature of colonialism in Canada.

Native Hope. (2024). *Missing and Murdered Indigenous Women (MMIW)*. Www.nativehope.org; Native Hope. https://www.nativehope.org/missing-and-murdered-indigenous-women-mmiw

Native Hope's publication on Missing and Murdered Indigenous Women (MMIW) discusses the systemic issues contributing to the high rates of violence against Indigenous women and girls in Canada. It highlights social, economic, and political factors that perpetuate this violence and the lack of adequate government response, emphasizing the need for national accountability and systemic reform. The publication also explores the cultural and intergenerational impacts of this crisis, calling for broader societal awareness and the integration of Indigenous-led solutions to address the root causes effectively.

Parrott, Z. (2006, February 7). *Indian Act*. The Canadian Encyclopedia; The Canadian Encyclopedia. https://www.thecanadianencyclopedia.ca/en/article/indian-act

Parrott's article on the Indian Act provides insight into the Canadian legal framework that has historically governed Indigenous peoples' lives. The Indian Act is critiqued for its oppressive policies that sought to assimilate Indigenous communities. Parrott explains how this act contributed to longstanding issues within Indigenous communities, including loss of autonomy and cultural suppression.

Srikanth, H. (2012). Multiculturalism and the Aboriginal Peoples in Canada. *Economic and Political Weekly*, *47*(23), 17–21. http://www.jstor.org/stable/23214913

In this journal article, Srikanth examines Canada's approach to multiculturalism and its implications for Indigenous communities. Srikanth argues that while multicultural policies aim to include diverse cultures, they often fail to address the unique political and cultural rights of Indigenous peoples. The article critiques Canadian multiculturalism as being insufficient in reconciling Indigenous sovereignty and cultural preservation.

Truth and Reconciliation Commission of Canada. (2015). *Honouring the Truth, Reconciling for the Future Honouring the Truth, Reconciling for the Future Summary of the Final Report of the Truth and Reconciliation Commission of Canada The Truth and Reconciliation Commission of Canada*. https://irsi.ubc.ca/sites/default/files/inline-files/Executive_Summary_English_Web.pdf

This foundational report summarizes the findings of the Truth and Reconciliation Commission, which investigated the history and legacy of residential schools in Canada. It outlines calls to action aimed at redressing past injustices and promoting reconciliation. The report has been instrumental in shaping public policy and dialogue around Indigenous rights and Canadian reconciliation efforts.

Urbanoski, K. A. (2017). Need for equity in treatment of substance use among Indigenous people in Canada. *Canadian Medical Association Journal*, *189*(44), E1350–E1351. https://doi.org/10.1503/cmaj.171002

In this publication for the *Canadian Medical Association Journal*, Urbanoski discusses the inequities in substance use treatment access for Indigenous people in Canada, emphasizing the need for culturally appropriate healthcare. The article highlights systemic barriers, such as lack of funding and cultural misunderstanding, that prevent Indigenous communities from receiving equitable substance use support, emphasizing a need for healthcare reforms. Urbanoski also calls for the incorporation of Indigenous knowledge and practices into treatment programs, advocating for approaches that respect and address the cultural and historical context of Indigenous health disparities.

Wayland, S. V. (1997). Immigration, Multiculturalism and National Identity in Canada. *International Journal on Minority and Group Rights*, *5*(1), 33–58. http://www.jstor.org/stable/24674516

Wayland's article examines Canada's national identity through the lens of multiculturalism and immigration policy, addressing how these policies intersect with Indigenous rights. Wayland argues that while Canada celebrates diversity, Indigenous concerns are often sidelined, as multicultural policies tend to favor immigrant communities over the needs and rights of Indigenous peoples. The article further critiques how this imbalance reflects a broader pattern of marginalization, wherein Indigenous sovereignty and historical injustices are overshadowed by narratives that prioritize Canada's image as a welcoming and inclusive nation.